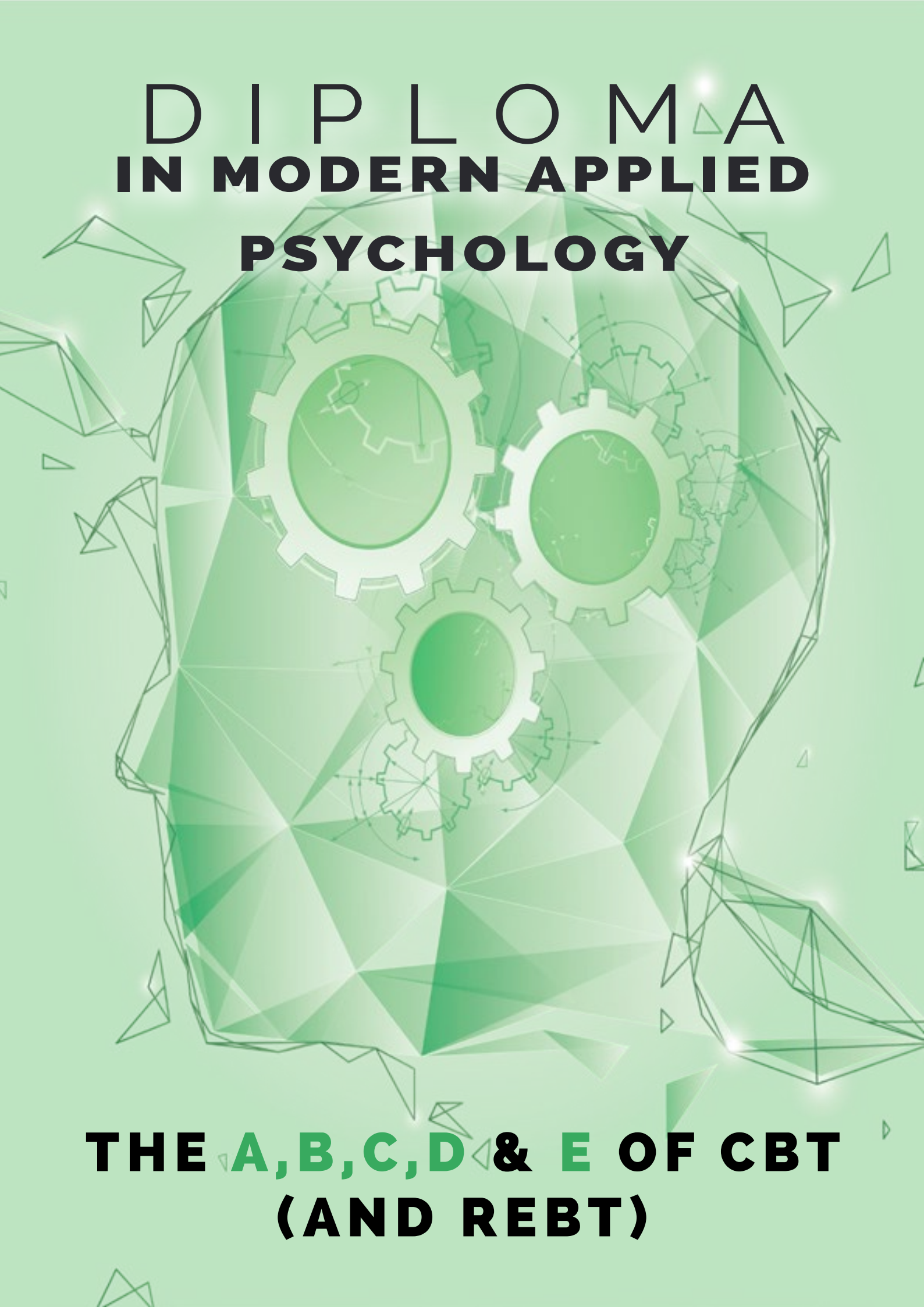


DIPLOMA IN MODERN APPLIED PSYCHOLOGY



THE A,B,C,D & E OF CBT
(AND REBT)

THE A,B,C,D, & E OF CBT (AND REBT)

People respond to being stuck in traffic differently. Where one person will honk their horn in rage, another will turn on some peaceful music and just sit and wait and another will become overwhelmed with anxiety because they're going to be late. Why do people have different reactions to stress and adversity?

Many people believe that negative events cause them to act in certain ways. However, research tells us that our reactions are based on our beliefs about the situation rather than the situation itself. When adversity happens, the first thing we attempt to do is explain to ourselves why it happened rather than examine what beliefs we have which caused us to feel the way we did.

Psychologist Dr Albert Ellis created the ABC model to help people understand the meaning of their reactions to adversity:

- A is the adversity—the event or situation.
- B is the belief or thought—our explanation about why the event/situation happened.
- C is the consequent emotion and behaviour—the feelings and behaviours our belief causes.
- D is the disputation of the belief
- E is the effect (i.e the cognitive shift which takes place)

A = Activating Event/Adversity

Activating events are triggers that cause potential stress. There are different types of stressors; for example, most people would find life event stressors, such as the death of a loved one, extremely difficult and stressful. Then there are 'daily hassles' which are more common stressors. Not everyone finds these daily hassles stressful because our individual beliefs, thoughts and perceptions regarding the daily hassles determine if the event is stressful for us or not.

B = Belief/Thought

When we're born, we come into this world as a clean slate: we have no beliefs, opinions, perceptions or views. As soon as we can talk and listen, we begin to learn the opinions of our parents, our peers, classmates, etc. We automatically begin using these beliefs as a template for interpreting ourselves, others and the world in general. The main problem is that others will not necessarily have the same template, beliefs and views as we do.

Individuals use their beliefs to interpret what is happening to them. These beliefs might be accurate, optimistic, possible and flexible, in which case, these types of beliefs or thinking skills can help to reduce the amount of stress a person experiences in life. However, a lot of beliefs take the form of automatic negative thoughts which are often rigid, inflexible and pessimistic and this can play a huge part in exacerbating an individual's stress levels. Fortunately, it's possible to change our beliefs and, as a result, reduce our stress levels.

The aim of the ABC model is about shifting the focus away from external events and onto our internal processing of the event (i.e. our beliefs). Our interpretation of the event is a subconscious reaction which occurs automatically. This idea developed from the Freudian Iceberg theory, which explores the concept that there are three levels of consciousness: the conscious, subconscious and unconscious.



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C = Consequent Emotion/Behaviour

The final part of the $A+B=C$ equation is Consequent Emotion/Behaviour. This refers to the feelings/behaviours that occur as a result of an individual's beliefs and self-talk in response to the trigger. These feelings/behaviours might include stress, fear, worry, anxiety, frustration, anger, aggression, depression, irritability, avoidance, social withdrawal, etc.

D = Disputation of Belief

This is where we consider what the healthier and more helpful perspective to adopt in our scenario (you might find the perceptual positions workbook helpful here). If we are operating out of our default world view, we will likely be triggered to relapse into what we regard as our default emotional response. The only way we can grow beyond our experience is by modifying our interpretation of our experience through questioning and critiquing ourselves.

E = Effect

This is the ultimate result after we analyse and critique our perceptions, i.e. a shift in how we interpret our perspective and how we relate to ourselves and our circumstances.

A never equals E: it's a process. $A + B + C + D = E$. Here's an example of the ABC framework applied to a young woman whose boyfriend has just ended their relationship who doesn't take steps D and E:

A = Activating Event = 'My boyfriend has left me.'

B = Belief = 'I can't live without him. Everyone always breaks up with me. There must be something wrong with me. Life isn't worth living without someone to love and care for me.'

C = Consequent Emotion/Behaviour = Feels depressed. Has no motivation to go out or do the things that she normally enjoys.

Here's an example of a different reaction that someone else might have to the same problem with steps D and E included.

A = Activating Event = 'My boyfriend has left me.'

B = Belief = 'I'm sad that it's over, but it's his choice to walk away. It'll take me time to get over this but I know this is not a reflection on me and I will be OK'.

C = Consequent Emotion/Behaviour = Feels sad the relationship has ended

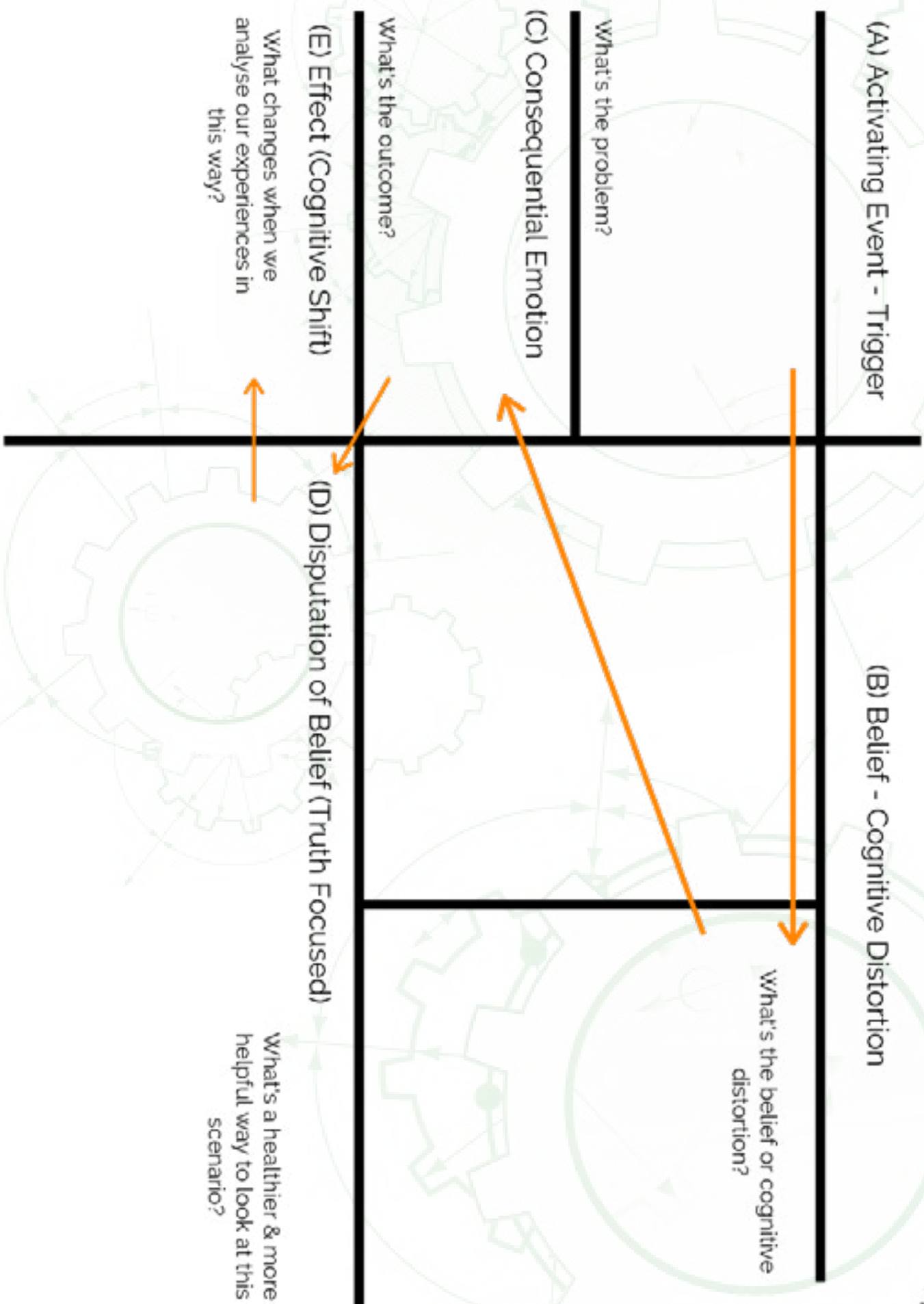
D = Disputation = Asks self 'am I really interpreting this wisely, maturely, or accurately? Or am I acting out of cognitive distortions? Am I personalising this? Are there factors which could be coming into play that I'm not recognising because I'm immersed in my own subjective experience?'

E = Effect = Still feels sad the relationship has ended, but recognising she was catastrophizing her situation (i.e. that time will heal and that she will find love again). She also recognises that relationships are still important (even after they end) because what we take away from them are the lessons we've learned which will help us develop and be better next time.

This ABC Framework helps individuals begin identifying their limiting beliefs and build awareness of how they think. By identifying thoughts that are often irrational, illogical and unhelpful, they can start to dispute them and begin to practise replacing them with healthier alternatives.



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